

Podcast 04 — Multi-Account Strategy

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Length target: 15 min (~2,200 spoken words) **Repo references:** `domain-1-organizational/05-aws-organizations.md`, `06-aws-control-tower.md`, `07-aws-ram.md`, `48-service-catalog.md`

Topic & Scope

Domain 1 weighting is heavy on multi-account governance. This podcast covers Organizations, SCPs, Control Tower, RAM, and Service Catalog — the four pillars of AWS landing zones.

Service Coverage Depth

Deep: - AWS Organizations — OUs, SCPs, consolidated billing - AWS Control Tower — landing zone, account factory, guardrails - Service Control Policies — the most-tested governance mechanism - AWS RAM — resource sharing across accounts - Service Catalog — self-service vending

Brief: - AppRegistry (mentioned in podcast 12) - Account Factory for Terraform (AFT)

Structured Outline

1. **Open (30s)** — “Multi-account is how AWS expects you to architect. Organizations + Control Tower + RAM + Service Catalog = the landing zone toolkit.”
2. **Organizations & OUs (3 min)** — management account vs member, OU hierarchy, consolidated billing
3. **SCPs Deep Dive (3 min)** — apply at root/OU/account, deny-list vs allow-list, FullAWSAccess implicit, common deny patterns
4. **Control Tower (3 min)** — opinionated landing zone, mandatory + strongly-recommended + elective guardrails, Account Factory
5. **RAM (2.5 min)** — share VPC subnets, Transit Gateway, License Manager configs, Resolver rules
6. **Service Catalog (2 min)** — vending compliant products to dev teams via launch role
7. **Rapid-Fire Trap Drill (60s)**

Must-Mention Exam Tips

- Organizations: management account creates Org; member accounts join
- Consolidated billing aggregates Org-wide; RI/SP sharing on by default
- SCPs attach to root, OU, or account
- SCPs are a CEILING — they don't grant, they restrict
- Default `FullAWSAccess` SCP attaches to everything — replace it for deny-list-only, otherwise allow-list-only enforced

- Control Tower = landing zone (Org + Identity Center + log archive + audit + guardrails baked in)
- Control Tower guardrails: mandatory (always on), strongly-recommended, elective
- Account Factory provisions new accounts with baseline applied
- RAM shares: VPC subnets, Transit Gateway, License Manager, Resolver rules, Outposts, ACM private certs, more
- RAM-shared resources show up natively in recipient accounts (not just IAM grant)
- Service Catalog launch role: user launches product without underlying IAM permission

Must-Mention Exam Traps

- EXAM TRAP: SCPs do NOT grant permissions — only restrict
- EXAM TRAP: SCPs do NOT apply to the management account by default
- EXAM TRAP: Control Tower deploys via CloudFormation StackSets — modifying outside Control Tower causes drift
- EXAM TRAP: Removing the FullAWSAccess SCP without replacing it BLOCKS everything in that account
- EXAM TRAP: RAM $\neq$ resource-based policy — RAM shares natively; resource policy is per-service
- EXAM TRAP: Service Catalog $\neq$ AWS Marketplace — Catalog is internal curated; Marketplace is third-party
- EXAM TRAP: Service Catalog launch role is the trick — without it, user still needs underlying IAM
- EXAM TRAP: Organizations consolidates billing whether SCPs are enabled or not — “all features” mode is needed for SCPs
- EXAM TRAP: AWS Config aggregator for org-wide compliance needs explicit setup
- EXAM TRAP: Some services bypass SCPs (signed URLs, support APIs) — check docs for edge cases

Key Decision Matrix

Scenario	Pick
Restrict every account in an OU from creating internet gateways	SCP
Auto-provision new accounts with baseline	Control Tower Account Factory
Share VPC subnets with other accounts	RAM
Vending compliant infrastructure to dev teams	Service Catalog
Consolidate billing across accounts	AWS Organizations consolidated billing
Centralize CloudTrail across all accounts	Organizations trail (multi-account)

Tone & Style

- Frame the whole multi-account world as a layered cake: Organizations is the plate, Control Tower the icing, SCPs the wire frame, RAM the bridges
- Repeat “SCPs do NOT grant” three times
- For Control Tower, name the four foundational OUs (Security, Sandbox, Workloads, Suspended)

Rapid-Fire Closer

“SCP grants?” — “NO.” “FullAWSAccess removed = ?” — “Everything denied.” “Share subnets with other accounts?” — “RAM.” “Vending compliant templates?” — “Service Catalog.” “Control Tower deploys via?” — “StackSets.”